The Complete Raw Feeding Guide for Your 95-Pound German Shepherd

A Comprehensive Textbook-Style Reference for Biologically Appropriate Raw Feeding

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Dog Profile: German Shepherd — 95 lbs, Adult
Diet Model: BARF / Prey Model Raw (Hybrid Approach)
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Chapter 1: Introduction to Raw Feeding

Raw feeding is the practice of feeding dogs a diet composed of uncooked, minimally processed whole foods — primarily animal-based proteins, bones, and organs — that mirror what canines would consume in the wild. This approach is grounded in the biological reality that dogs are facultative carnivores whose digestive systems evolved over thousands of years to process raw animal matter efficiently.

The German Shepherd, as a breed, is particularly well-suited to a raw diet. As a working dog with high energy demands, a robust digestive system, and a genetic history closely tied to wolf ancestry, the German Shepherd thrives on protein-dense, nutrient-rich whole food nutrition. Many common GSD health issues — including digestive sensitivity, skin and coat problems, joint inflammation, and immune dysfunction — have been reported by owners and some holistic veterinarians to improve significantly when switching from processed kibble to a properly formulated raw diet.

Why Raw Over Kibble?

Commercial dry dog food (kibble) is highly processed, cooked at temperatures that destroy natural enzymes, degrade protein quality, and eliminate moisture. It typically contains significant amounts of grain, starch, and synthetic vitamins added back in after processing destroys the natural ones. In contrast, a properly balanced raw diet provides:

- **Bioavailable protein** from whole animal sources with complete amino acid profiles
- **Natural moisture content** (50–70% water in raw meat vs. 8–10% in kibble), supporting kidney function and hydration
- **Raw enzymes and probiotics** that support gut health and nutrient absorption
- **Whole food micronutrients** that are more readily absorbed than synthetic supplements
- **Natural dental cleaning** from chewing raw meaty bones — no more tartar buildup
- **Smaller, firmer, less odorous stools** — a direct result of higher digestibility
- **Improved coat quality, skin health, and muscle tone**

Is Raw Feeding Safe?

Yes — when handled properly. The primary concerns around raw feeding involve bacterial contamination (Salmonella, E. coli, Listeria) and nutritional imbalance. Both are entirely manageable:

- Healthy dogs have highly acidic stomachs (pH 1–2) and short digestive tracts designed to handle bacterial loads that would harm humans
- Safe food handling practices (the same you use preparing your own food) eliminate cross-contamination risk
- Following the nutritional ratios in this guide ensures balanced nutrition over time

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Chapter 2: Understanding the Two Raw Feeding Models

Two primary frameworks guide raw feeding. Understanding both allows you to adopt the best hybrid approach for your German Shepherd.

Model 1: BARF (Biologically Appropriate Raw Food)

Developed by Australian veterinarian Dr. Ian Billinghurst, BARF incorporates both animal and plant-based ingredients, acknowledging that dogs, as scavengers, consume some plant matter in the wild (typically through the gut contents of prey animals).

BARF Ratios (by weight):

Component	Percentage
Muscle Meat	70%
Raw Meaty Bones	10%
Liver	5%
Other Secreting Organs	5%
Vegetables & Fruits	10%

Model 2: Prey Model Raw (PMR)

PMR attempts to replicate the whole prey animal more precisely, eliminating vegetables and plant matter entirely based on the argument that dogs are obligate-leaning carnivores.

PMR Ratios (by weight):

Component	Percentage
Muscle Meat (incl. heart)	80%
Raw Meaty Bones	10%
Liver	5%
Other Secreting Organs	5%

Recommended Approach: The Hybrid Model

For a 95-pound adult German Shepherd, this guide recommends a **BARF-leaning hybrid** — prioritizing animal protein and organs while including a modest amount of nutrient-dense vegetables to fill micronutrient gaps, particularly for dogs not eating whole prey.

Hybrid Ratios Used Throughout This Guide:

Component	Percentage	Daily Amount (95 lb GSD)
Muscle Meat	65%	~1.56 lbs
Raw Meaty Bones	15%	~0.36 lbs
Liver	5%	~0.12 lbs
Other Secreting Organs	5%	~0.12 lbs
Vegetables & Fruits	7%	~0.17 lbs
Eggs, Canned Fish, Supplements	3%	~0.07 lbs
TOTAL	**100%**	**~2.4 lbs/day**

Chapter 3: Calculating Daily Food Requirements

Base Calculation

The standard starting point for adult raw-fed dogs is **2–3% of body weight per day**, adjusted for activity level, metabolism, and body condition.

For a 95-pound German Shepherd:

Activity Level	Percentage	Daily Amount
Low (senior, sedentary)	2.0%	1.90 lbs
Moderate (daily walks)	2.5%	2.38 lbs
Active (working, exercise daily)	3.0%	2.85 lbs
High performance (sport, working dog)	3.5%+	3.33 lbs+

Starting point: Begin at **2.5%** = **approximately 2.4 lbs per day** and adjust based on your dog's body condition over 4–6 weeks.

Body Condition Scoring (BCS)

Use the 9-point BCS scale to calibrate intake:

- **BCS 1–3 (too thin):** Ribs, spine, and hips visible — increase to 3% or higher
- **BCS 4–5 (ideal):** Ribs easily felt but not seen, waist visible from above — maintain current intake
- **BCS 6–7 (overweight):** Ribs felt with pressure, waist barely visible — reduce to 2%
- **BCS 8–9 (obese):** Ribs not palpable, no waist — reduce to 1.5–1.8% and consult vet

Check BCS monthly. Raw feeding is not "set and forget" — dial in portions based on your individual dog.

Feeding Frequency

Age	Meals Per Day
Puppy (8–12 weeks)	4 meals
Puppy (3–6 months)	3 meals
Puppy (6–12 months)	2 meals
Adult (1+ years)	1–2 meals
Senior (7+ years)	2 meals (easier digestion)

For your adult GSD: Feed **2 meals per day** — approximately 1.2 lbs per meal. Some adult dogs do well on one large meal. Monitor stool quality and energy to determine preference.

Chapter 4: The Six Nutritional Components

A complete raw diet for your 95-pound German Shepherd is built from six categories, each serving a specific nutritional function:

1. **Muscle Meat** — Primary protein and fat source; amino acids for muscle, enzymes, energy
2. **Raw Meaty Bones (RMB)** — Calcium and phosphorus; dental health; joint support
3. **Liver** — Vitamin A, B vitamins, iron, copper, folate; the most nutrient-dense food on earth
4. **Secreting Organs** — Kidney, spleen, pancreas, thymus — hormonal and enzymatic support
5. **Vegetables & Fruits** — Phytonutrients, fiber, antioxidants, vitamin C
6. **Boosters** — Eggs, oily fish, kelp, probiotics — targeted micronutrient support

Key principle: Nutritional balance is achieved OVER TIME, not in every single meal. Think of it like your own diet — not every meal is perfectly balanced, but the week as a whole covers all bases. Rotate proteins and organs across the week.

Chapter 5: Muscle Meat — The Foundation

Muscle meat forms 65% of your GSD's raw diet. It provides complete protein with all essential amino acids, B vitamins, zinc, iron, phosphorus, and natural fats.

Recommended Muscle Meat Sources

Beef:

- Chuck, brisket, stew meat, ground beef (80/20 fat ratio)
- High in zinc, iron, B12, and creatine
- Excellent for muscular German Shepherds
- Feed 3–4 times per week

Chicken:

- Thighs (preferred over breast — higher fat and flavor)
- Ground chicken, whole legs without bone for muscle meat portions
- Easy to source, affordable, high in niacin and selenium
- Feed 2–3 times per week

Turkey:

- Ground turkey, turkey thighs, turkey necks (as RMB, not muscle meat)
- High in tryptophan — calming amino acid
- Excellent lean option
- Feed 1–2 times per week

Pork:

- Pork shoulder, pork heart (classified as muscle meat), ground pork
- High in B1 (thiamine), selenium, phosphorus
- Note: freeze pork for 3 weeks at 0°F before feeding to eliminate any Trichinella risk
- Feed 1–2 times per week

Lamb:

- Ground lamb, lamb shoulder, lamb leg
- High in zinc, B12, conjugated linoleic acid (CLA)
- Excellent for dogs with chicken or beef sensitivities
- Feed 1–2 times per week

Venison (Deer):

- Extremely lean, high-protein, anti-inflammatory
- Excellent novel protein for dogs with food sensitivities
- Feed 1–2 times per week when available

Duck:

- Ground duck, duck breast
- Higher fat content — good for underweight dogs or high-activity GSDs
- Rich in iron and selenium
- Feed 1 time per week

Rabbit:

- Whole ground rabbit (excellent whole-prey option)
- Very lean — excellent for weight management
- High in B12 and phosphorus
- Feed 1 time per week

Goat:

- Ground goat, goat shoulder
- Lean, easily digestible
- High in iron and potassium
- Feed occasionally

Daily Muscle Meat Target for 95-lb GSD:

~1.56 lbs (25 oz) of muscle meat per day

Spread across 2 meals: approximately 0.78 lbs (12.5 oz) per meal.

Heart Meat — Special Classification

Heart is a muscle meat, not an organ. It is one of the most nutrient-dense muscle meats available:

- **Beef heart:** Extremely high in CoQ10 (coenzyme Q10), an antioxidant critical for heart and mitochondrial function; high in B vitamins, iron, zinc
- **Chicken heart:** Rich in taurine — essential for cardiac health in dogs
- **Pork heart:** High in selenium and B12

Feed heart 2–3 times per week, making up 10–15% of the muscle meat portion. For your 95-lb GSD, that's approximately 2–4 oz of heart per meal it's included in.

Chapter 6: Raw Meaty Bones — The Calcium Source

Raw meaty bones (RMB) serve as the primary calcium and phosphorus source in a raw diet, replacing the need for supplemental calcium. They also provide mental stimulation, dental cleaning, and joint-supporting collagen and marrow.

> ⚠️ **CRITICAL SAFETY RULE:** NEVER feed cooked bones of any kind. Cooked bones become brittle, splinter into sharp shards, and can perforate the esophagus, stomach, or intestines. RAW bones only.

Bone Selection for a 95-lb German Shepherd

German Shepherds are powerful chewers. Choose bones appropriate for the size and jaw strength of a large breed:

Excellent choices (size-appropriate, safe for large dogs):

Bone	Animal	Notes
Chicken quarter (leg + thigh)	Chicken	Soft bone — great beginner bone; feed 2–3x/week
Turkey neck	Turkey	Soft, flexible — excellent dental cleaner; feed 1–2x/week
Duck neck	Duck	Softer than turkey; good variety
Pork neck bones	Pork	Slightly harder — good chewing challenge
Beef rib bones (short rib)	Beef	Semi-recreational — some marrow benefit
Lamb neck	Lamb	Soft, meaty — excellent RMB

Rabbit (whole or split)	Rabbit	Soft, entire skeleton edible
Chicken back	Chicken	Very soft, high bone-to-meat ratio

Recreational bones (for enrichment, not nutritional bone):

Bone	Notes
Beef knuckle bone	Very hard — recreational only; remove after 30 min; do NOT feed weight-bearing beef bones (femur, marrow pipe) — too hard, can crack teeth
Beef rib (large)	Recreational; supervise always

Bones to AVOID for Large Dogs

- **Weight-bearing beef bones** (femur, knuckle if very dense) — can fracture large breed teeth (slab fractures)
- **Pork ribs (cooked)** — never cooked
- **Fish bones from large fish** — can be sharp (small sardines/mackerel are fine whole)
- **Any bone that can be swallowed whole** — size up to prevent gulp-and-swallow

Daily Bone Target for 95-lb GSD:

~0.36 lbs (5.8 oz) of raw meaty bone per day

This can be fed as a whole bone meal (e.g., 2 chicken quarters = ~1 lb, fed every other day) rather than small portions every meal. Many raw feeders feed bone-in meals 3–4 days per week and boneless meals the remaining days.

Bone Feeding Frequency Option:

- **Option A (Daily):** Small amount of soft bone every meal (e.g., half a chicken neck in each meal)
- **Option B (Every Other Day):** Full bone meal every 2 days (e.g., 2 chicken quarters)
- **Option C (3x/Week):** Bone meal 3 times per week, boneless on remaining days

Whichever option, **monitor stool consistency as your bone indicator:**

- White, chalky, crumbly stool = too much bone (reduce)
- Loose, slimy stool = too little bone (increase)
- Firm, brown, small stool that crumbles after 24 hours = perfect balance

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Chapter 7: Organ Meats — The Multivitamin

Organs are the most nutrient-dense component of the raw diet. Gram for gram, liver and other secreting organs contain more vitamins and minerals than any plant-based food or synthetic supplement. However, overfeeding organs — especially liver — causes loose stool and, in excess, vitamin A toxicity over time.

Two Categories of Organs

Category 1: Liver (must be fed specifically)

Liver is nutritionally distinct from other organs and must comprise exactly 5% of the diet — no more, no less. For your 95-lb GSD:

Daily liver target: ~0.12 lbs (approximately 1.9 oz) per day

Best practice: Feed liver 2–3 times per week in larger amounts rather than daily micro-doses.

Liver Type	Notes	Frequency
Beef liver	Highest nutrient density; large size easy to portion	2–3x/week
Chicken liver	Milder flavor; excellent for picky eaters	2–3x/week
Pork liver	Slightly more bitter; good variety	1–2x/week
Lamb liver	Rich, highly palatable	1–2x/week
Duck liver	Richest in fat; use sparingly	1x/week
Venison liver	Lean, excellent for sensitivity cases	As available

> ⚠️ **Important:** Do not exceed liver beyond 5% of total diet. Vitamin A (retinol) is fat-soluble and accumulates. Long-term over-supplementation causes hypervitaminosis A, leading to bone spurs and joint disease — particularly problematic in a breed already prone to hip dysplasia.

Category 2: Secreting Organs (the "other 5%")

Secreting organs are glands that produce hormones or secretions (as opposed to liver, which is a processing organ). They provide a completely different micronutrient profile than liver and are essential for hormonal, immune, and enzymatic function.

Daily secreting organ target: ~0.12 lbs (~1.9 oz) per day

Organ	Source	Key Nutrients	Feeding Frequency
Kidney	Beef, pork, lamb	Selenium, B12, riboflavin, CoQ10	2–3x/week
Spleen	Beef, pork	Iron, zinc, vitamin C, protein	1–2x/week
Pancreas	Beef, pork	Digestive enzymes, B vitamins	1x/week
Thymus (sweetbreads)	Beef, lamb	Thymosin, zinc, immune peptides	1x/week
Brain	Beef, lamb	Omega-3 DHA, phospholipids	1x/week (small amount)
Testicle	Beef, lamb	Testosterone precursors, zinc, protein	Occasional
Lung	Beef, lamb	Taurine, protein, elastin	1–2x/week (some classify as muscle)
Eyeball	Beef	Lutein, taurine, omega-3s	Occasional

Organ Feeding Tips

1. **Introduce organs slowly** — even 0.5 oz of liver per day to start; loose stool is the sign you've added too much too fast
2. **Freeze organs before first feeding** (3 weeks at 0°F) — reduces bacterial load

3. **Rotate organ sources** — don't feed only beef liver; rotate with chicken liver, kidney from different sources
4. **If your dog refuses organs** — try lightly searing the exterior (no more than 10 seconds per side), hiding them in ground meat, or freezing and grating frozen over the meal

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Chapter 8: Vegetables, Fruits & Plant Matter

Vegetables and fruits constitute approximately 7% of your GSD's diet in the BARF hybrid model. The key rule: **vegetables must be pulped, pureed, or lightly steamed** before feeding. Dogs lack the enzyme amylase in saliva (unlike humans) and cannot break down intact plant cell walls. Pulping or cooking ruptures the cells and releases the nutrients.

Best Vegetables for German Shepherds

Vegetable	Preparation	Key Nutrients	Notes
Kale	Pulped/blended	Vitamins K, A, C; calcium; antioxidants	Feed 2–3x/week
Spinach	Pulped	Iron, folate, vitamin K	Limit — high oxalates; 1–2x/week
Broccoli	Pulped or lightly steamed	Sulforaphane, vitamin C, fiber	Feed 1–2x/week; high in glucosinolates
Carrots	Grated or pureed raw	Beta-carotene, vitamin A, fiber	Excellent; daily is fine
Zucchini	Grated raw or blended	Potassium, B vitamins, low calorie	Daily is fine
Cucumber	Diced or blended	Hydration, vitamin K	Good summer option
Celery	Pureed	Vitamin K, folate, potassium	Feed 2–3x/week
Beets	Cooked and blended	Folate, manganese, detox support	Feed 1–2x/week
Sweet potato	Cooked	Vitamin A, fiber, potassium	High glycemic — use sparingly
Pumpkin (plain canned)	Ready to use	Soluble fiber — excellent for loose stool	Feed 1–2 tbsp as needed
Parsley	Chopped fresh	Vitamin C, breath freshening	Small amounts; avoid in pregnancy

Best Fruits for German Shepherds

Fruit	Key Nutrients	Serving	Notes
Blueberries	Antioxidants, vitamin C	3–5 berries	Anti-inflammatory; excellent
Watermelon (seedless)	Lycopene, hydration	Small chunk	Remove seeds and rind
Apple	Fiber, vitamin C	2–3 slices	Remove seeds and core — contain cyanogenic glycosides

Banana	Potassium, B6, magnesium	Half banana	High sugar — limit frequency
Mango	Vitamin A, C, folate	Small piece	Remove pit — choking hazard
Pineapple	Bromelain (anti-inflammatory enzyme)	1–2 chunks	Fresh only — bromelain destroyed by canning
Cranberries	Proanthocyanidins (UTI prevention)	Small handful	Tart; mix into food

Vegetables & Fruits to AVOID

Food	Reason
Grapes / raisins	Causes acute kidney failure — potentially fatal
Onions / garlic / leeks / chives	Thiosulfates destroy red blood cells — causes hemolytic anemia
Avocado	Persin — toxic to dogs; causes vomiting, diarrhea
Tomato (unripe/green)	Solanine — toxic in unripe state
Rhubarb	Oxalic acid — toxic to kidneys
Mushrooms (wild)	Many varieties severely toxic; store-bought generally safe
Macadamia nuts	Toxicity mechanism unknown; causes weakness, hyperthermia
Corn on the cob	Choking and intestinal obstruction risk

Chapter 9: Supplements

A properly rotated raw diet should provide most essential nutrients. However, several targeted supplements are recommended to fill known gaps, particularly for German Shepherds:

Essential Supplements

1. Fish Oil (Omega-3 Fatty Acids)

- **Why:** Balances omega-6:omega-3 ratio (raw meat is high in omega-6); reduces inflammation; supports coat, skin, joints, and brain
- **Source:** Wild-caught sardine oil, salmon oil, or whole sardines/mackerel in water (canned)
- **Dose for 95-lb GSD:** 2,000–3,000 mg EPA + DHA per day
- **Practical:** Feed 2–3 whole canned sardines in water (no salt) 3–4x per week, OR 1 tsp sardine/salmon oil daily
- **Storage:** Refrigerate after opening; discard after 60 days

2. Vitamin E

- **Why:** Fish oil supplementation increases need for vitamin E (prevents oxidation of omega-3s within the body); antioxidant; supports immune function
- **Dose:** 200–400 IU vitamin E (mixed tocopherols) per day when feeding fish oil
- **Source:** Capsule pierced and squeezed over food

3. Kelp and/or Iodine

- **Why:** Raw diets can be low in iodine; thyroid function depends on iodine; German Shepherds are prone to hypothyroidism
- **Source:** Dried kelp powder
- **Dose:** 1/4 tsp kelp powder per day for a 95-lb dog
- **Note:** Do not exceed — excess iodine also disrupts thyroid

4. Probiotics

- **Why:** Supports gut microbiome during dietary transition and long-term; reduces pathogenic bacterial load; enhances immunity
- **Sources (whole food preferred):**
  - Plain, unsweetened goat's milk kefir: 2–4 tbsp per day
  - Plain organic yogurt: 1–2 tbsp per day
  - Fermented vegetables (plain): 1 tsp per day
- **Supplement option:** Canine-specific probiotic with Lactobacillus acidophilus and Bifidobacterium strains

5. Eggs

- **Why:** Complete protein; richest food source of biotin, choline, and selenium; contain all fat-soluble vitamins; the egg yolk is one of the most nutrient-dense foods available
- **Dose:** 3–5 whole raw eggs per week for a 95-lb dog
- **Feeding method:** Raw, whole (yolk and white), cracked over meal
- **Note:** Egg whites contain avidin, which blocks biotin absorption — feeding the whole egg (yolk + white) neutralizes this. Feeding ONLY egg whites is not recommended

6. Bone Broth

- **Why:** Joint support (glucosamine, chondroitin, collagen); gut lining support; excellent palatability booster for picky eaters or sick dogs
- **Preparation:** Simmer beef or chicken bones (knuckles, feet, marrow bones) with 1–2 tbsp apple cider vinegar for 12–24 hours; strain; refrigerate; skim fat
- **Dose:** Pour 2–4 oz over meals 3–4 times per week
- **Note:** Homemade ONLY — store-bought bone broth often contains onion, garlic, and high sodium

Conditional Supplements

Supplement	When to Use	Dose
Turmeric + black pepper	Joint inflammation, anti-inflammatory support	1/4 tsp turmeric + pinch black pepper in "golden paste" form
Coconut oil	Coat health, gut support, MCT energy	1 tsp per day — do not overfeed (causes loose stool)
Milk thistle	Liver detox support during transition or long-term	70–100 mg silymarin per day
Colostrum	Immune support, gut healing, allergy reduction	Per product label
Digestive enzymes	If loose stool persists after transition	Canine enzyme formula with lipase, protease, amylase

Zinc	If feeding primarily low-zinc proteins	15–25 mg zinc picolinate/gluconate — GSDs can be zinc-deficient

Chapter 10: Weekly Meal Planning & Rotation Schedule

The goal of rotation is nutritional diversity. No single protein source provides everything. Rotating across 4–6 different proteins per week ensures broad amino acid, fatty acid, and micronutrient coverage.

Sample 7-Day Meal Plan (95-lb GSD, 2.4 lbs/day, 2 meals/day)

MONDAY

Meal	Ingredients	Amount
Morning	Ground beef (80/20)	10 oz
Morning	Beef kidney	1.5 oz
Morning	Blueberries	4–5 berries
Evening	Chicken quarters (bone-in)	14 oz
Evening	Beef liver	2 oz
Evening	Kale (pulped)	1.5 oz
Evening	1 whole raw egg	—

TUESDAY

Meal	Ingredients	Amount
Morning	Ground turkey	10 oz
Morning	Turkey neck (bone-in)	6 oz
Morning	Chicken liver	2 oz
Morning	Zucchini (grated)	1.5 oz
Evening	Beef heart (muscle meat)	12 oz
Evening	Beef spleen	1.5 oz
Evening	Carrots (grated)	1.5 oz
Evening	Sardines in water (1 whole)	—

WEDNESDAY — Bone Day

Meal	Ingredients	Amount
Morning	Raw lamb shoulder (boneless)	12 oz
Morning	Lamb liver	2 oz
Morning	Spinach (pulped)	1 oz
Evening	Pork neck bones (bone-in)	16 oz
Evening	Pork kidney	1.5 oz
Evening	Apple slices (2–3, no seeds)	—

Evening	Goat milk kefir	3 tbsp

THURSDAY

Meal	Ingredients	Amount
Morning	Ground duck	10 oz
Morning	Beef thymus (sweetbreads)	1.5 oz
Morning	Broccoli (pulped/steamed)	1.5 oz
Evening	Chicken thighs (boneless)	12 oz
Evening	Chicken liver	2 oz
Evening	Chicken heart	2 oz
Evening	2 whole raw eggs	—
Evening	1/4 tsp kelp powder	—

FRIDAY

Meal	Ingredients	Amount
Morning	Ground pork (freeze first)	10 oz
Morning	Pork liver	2 oz
Morning	Celery (pureed)	1.5 oz
Morning	Watermelon (small chunk)	—
Evening	Beef chuck (cubed or ground)	12 oz
Evening	Beef kidney	1.5 oz
Evening	Beets (cooked, pureed)	1.5 oz
Evening	Bone broth	3 oz poured over

SATURDAY — Whole Prey / Rabbit Day

Meal	Ingredients	Amount
Morning	Whole ground rabbit	18 oz
Morning	Rabbit liver (included in grind or add)	1.5 oz
Morning	Parsley (fresh, chopped)	small pinch
Evening	Beef heart	12 oz
Evening	Lamb kidney	1.5 oz
Evening	Pumpkin (plain canned)	2 tbsp
Evening	Sardines in water (2 whole)	—

SUNDAY — Rest / Simple Day

Meal	Ingredients	Amount
Morning	Ground beef (lean)	12 oz
Morning	Beef liver	2 oz
Morning	Kefir	3 tbsp

Evening	Chicken quarters (bone-in)	16 oz
Evening	Zucchini + carrot (grated mix)	2 oz
Evening	1 whole raw egg	—
Evening	Fish oil capsule (pierced)	1 capsule

Weekly Nutritional Checklist

By end of each week, confirm you've fed:

- [ ] 4–6 different protein sources (beef, chicken, turkey, pork, lamb, duck, rabbit, venison)
- [ ] Liver from at least 2 different animal species
- [ ] At least 2 different secreting organs (kidney, spleen, pancreas, thymus)
- [ ] Bone-in meals 3–4 days
- [ ] Eggs 3–5 times
- [ ] Oily fish (sardines/mackerel/salmon) 3–4 times
- [ ] At least 3 different vegetables
- [ ] 2–3 different fruits
- [ ] Probiotics (kefir or yogurt) 4–5 times

Chapter 11: Preparing Raw Meals — Step by Step

Equipment You'll Need

Item	Purpose
Digital kitchen scale	Weighing portions accurately
Large cutting board (dedicated raw meat board)	Meal prep
Sharp boning/chef's knife	Portioning meat and bones
Food processor or blender	Pulping vegetables
Silicone ice cube trays or freezer bags	Portioning and freezing organs
Airtight glass or stainless containers	2-day refrigerator storage
Freezer-safe zip bags	Bulk meat storage
Permanent marker	Labeling bags with protein type and date

Batch Prep Method (Recommended — Once Weekly)

Raw feeding is far more manageable when you batch prep once per week rather than preparing from scratch daily.

Step 1 — Shop and source Purchase 1–2 weeks of proteins. Aim for variety: 2 lbs of several different proteins rather than a large amount of one. Butchers, Asian grocery stores, ethnic markets, restaurant supply stores, and raw pet food co-ops are the best sources.

Step 2 — Freeze new proteins immediately Any pork products: freeze for 3 full weeks before use (kills Trichinella). All other proteins: freeze 1 week for added safety (optional but recommended for new feeders).

Step 3 — Portion organs into single-serving trays Liver and other organs are typically sold in large pieces. Slice into daily portions (approximately 2 oz for your 95-lb GSD) and freeze flat on a sheet pan, then transfer to a labeled freezer bag. Pull one portion per day.

Step 4 — Prep vegetables Run a weekly batch of vegetables through the food processor. Store pulped veg in a sealed container in the refrigerator. Use within 5 days. Add 1–2 oz per meal.

Step 5 — Thaw in the refrigerator Move 2 days worth of meat from freezer to refrigerator each night. Never thaw on the counter at room temperature — use refrigerator thawing only. Thawed raw meat keeps 2–3 days in the fridge.

Step 6 — Assemble meals At mealtime: weigh out muscle meat portion → add bone (if bone day) → add organ → add vegetable → add any supplements or boosters. Mix briefly. Serve.

Step 7 — Serve at room temperature Cold meat from the refrigerator straight into the bowl is fine, but slightly warming it (set the container in warm water for a few minutes) can increase palatability, especially for new raw feeders.

Portioning Hack for Beginners

Purchase a **digital postal scale** or kitchen scale accurate to 0.1 oz. Weigh every meal for the first 4–6 weeks until you develop an accurate visual sense of correct portions. Over- or under-feeding by 20% over months adds up.

Chapter 12: Safe Food Handling & Storage

Raw meat contains bacteria (Salmonella, E. coli, Listeria, Campylobacter) that, while typically harmless to healthy adult dogs, can make humans sick. Follow the same hygiene practices you use preparing your own food:

Handling Rules

1. **Wash hands** with soap and warm water for 20 seconds before and after handling raw meat
2. **Use a dedicated cutting board** — color-coded boards (red for raw meat) reduce cross-contamination
3. **Disinfect surfaces** after prep with a 1:32 bleach solution (1/2 tsp bleach per quart of water) or food-safe sanitizer
4. **Do not allow the dog to lick your face** immediately after eating raw (normal affection is fine after the dog's mouth has self-cleaned)
5. **Wash the food bowl** with hot water and dish soap after every meal
6. **Supervise bone feeding** — especially for dogs new to raw

Storage Guidelines

Item	Refrigerator	Freezer
Fresh ground meat	1–2 days	3–4 months
Whole muscle cuts	3–5 days	4–6 months
Organs (fresh)	1–2 days	3–4 months

Organs (portioned, frozen)	Thaw before use	3–4 months
Bone-in pieces	3–4 days	4–6 months
Thawed meat (previously frozen)	2 days	Do NOT refreeze
Pulped vegetables	5 days	1 month (in cubes)
Bone broth	5 days	6 months (in ice cube trays)

The 20-Minute Rule

Remove uneaten food after 20 minutes and refrigerate or discard. Raw meat left at room temperature beyond 2 hours approaches unsafe bacterial load, even for dogs.

Chapter 13: Transitioning from Kibble to Raw

The transition process is important. Mixing raw and kibble in the same meal is generally not recommended — kibble digests at a much slower rate than raw (12–24 hours vs. 4–6 hours), which can cause digestive upset and gas as the two foods ferment together in the stomach.

Transition Method 1: The Cold Turkey Switch (Recommended for Healthy Adults)

1. Feed last kibble meal one evening
2. Next morning: begin raw with a single, simple protein (chicken or turkey — bland and easy to digest)
3. Stick with ONE protein for 2 weeks — no variety until stools normalize
4. Introduce second protein after 2 weeks if stools are firm
5. Add organs in the third week — start with just a few grams per day and build up

Expected stool changes during transition:

- Days 1–5: Loose, mucus-coated, or slightly slimy stools are normal (gut is detoxing and adjusting)
- Days 5–14: Stools firm up, become smaller and darker
- Week 3+: Ideal raw stools — small, firm, brown, crumble within 24 hours

Transition Method 2: The Gradual Switch (For Sensitive Dogs)

If your dog has a known sensitive stomach or digestive issues:

Week	Kibble %	Raw %
Week 1	75%	25%
Week 2	50%	50%
Week 3	25%	75%
Week 4	0%	100%

Feed kibble and raw at **separate meals** (morning kibble, evening raw) rather than mixing in the same bowl.

Transition Tips

- **Expect detox symptoms:** Eye discharge, increased shedding, and brief lethargy in the first 1–2 weeks are common as the body processes the dietary change
- **Add digestive enzymes** during transition to ease the shift
- **Add a probiotic** immediately (kefir or supplement) to support gut flora change
- **Feed organs last** — get muscle meat and bone digestion established first
- **If serious GI distress** occurs (bloody diarrhea, severe vomiting) — return to bland single protein and slow down the transition

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Chapter 14: Monitoring Health on a Raw Diet

Key Indicators of a Well-Balanced Raw Diet

Stool Quality (your primary feedback mechanism)

Stool Appearance	What It Means	Action
Firm, small, brown, crumbles in 24h	✓ Ideal	No change
White/chalky, very hard	Too much bone	Reduce bone
Loose, liquid, yellow	Too little bone OR too much organ	Reduce organ; add bone
Slimy, mucus coating	Normal during transition	Monitor
Very dark or tarry	Too much liver	Reduce liver significantly
Bloody	Concern — contact vet	Veterinary evaluation

Coat and Skin

- Improved coat shine and density expected within 6–8 weeks
- Reduced dandruff and flaking
- Reduced skin odor ("dog smell")
- If coat worsens: check omega-3 supplementation (add more fish)

Dental Health

- Within 4–6 weeks of regular bone feeding: visible tartar reduction
- Whiter teeth, fresher breath
- If not improving: add more recreational bone chewing time

Energy Levels

- Stable, sustained energy throughout the day (vs. kibble energy spikes after meals)
- German Shepherds typically show improved stamina and recovery on raw

Body Condition

- Reassess BCS monthly using rib/waist assessment
- Adjust food amount by 0.1–0.2 lbs increments based on BCS trend

Regular Veterinary Bloodwork

- Annual bloodwork minimum; ideally every 6 months

- Key markers to track: albumin, BUN (blood urea nitrogen), creatinine, liver enzymes (ALT, AST), calcium, phosphorus, vitamin D (25-OH), B12, iron/ferritin, thyroid panel (T3/T4/TSH)
- Inform your vet you are feeding a raw diet — some vets are unfamiliar but the labs tell the objective story

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Chapter 15: Foods That Are Toxic or Dangerous

Never feed any of the following to your German Shepherd:

Definitively Toxic

Food	Toxic Effect
Grapes, raisins, currants	Acute kidney failure — potentially fatal even in small amounts
Onions, garlic, leeks, chives, shallots	Thiosulfates — hemolytic anemia (destroys red blood cells)
Xylitol (artificial sweetener)	Severe hypoglycemia, liver failure — often in peanut butter, gum, baked goods
Chocolate / caffeine / theobromine	Cardiac arrhythmia, seizures, death
Avocado	Persin — vomiting, diarrhea, respiratory distress
Macadamia nuts	Weakness, hyperthermia, vomiting, neurological effects
Alcohol	Liver and brain damage
Cooked bones	Splintering — internal lacerations, perforation, obstruction
Raw salmon / trout from Pacific Northwest	Neorickettsia helminthoeca (salmon poisoning) — fatal if untreated; cook or freeze these specific fish
Nutmeg	Myristicin — neurological toxicity
Unripe tomato, tomato plants	Solanine — gastrointestinal distress, neurological effects

High-Risk / Limit Strictly

Food	Risk
Liver (excess)	Vitamin A toxicity — hypervitaminosis A causing bone spurs
Raw whole wild-caught salmon (unfrozen, Pacific coast)	Salmon poisoning disease
Pork (uncooked, not frozen)	Trichinella spiralis — freeze 3 weeks at 0°F to eliminate
Whole fish bones (large fish)	Sharp, non-digestible — use small fish (sardines, mackerel) only
Raw egg whites only	Avidin blocks biotin — always feed the whole egg
Fat trimmings (excessive)	Pancreatitis risk — use moderate fat meats

Large weight-bearing beef bones	Tooth fracture risk — slab fractures

Chapter 16: Sourcing & Cost Breakdown

Best Places to Source Raw Dog Food

Budget-Friendly Sources:

- **Asian grocery stores / international markets** — organs (liver, kidney, tripe, hearts, lung) at very low cost; often have whole chickens, duck, rabbit
- **Local butchers** — ask for trimmings, organs, necks, backs (often discounted or free)
- **Restaurant supply stores (Sysco, US Foods)** — bulk ground meat, chicken, organ meats
- **Ethnic grocery stores** — excellent source of variety proteins and offal
- **Farmers markets** — grass-fed beef, pastured pork, lamb, rabbit

Mid-Range Sources:

- **Costco / Sam's Club** — bulk ground beef, chicken leg quarters, pork shoulder
- **Restaurant Depot** — membership-based, wholesale pricing on bulk proteins
- **Raw pet food co-ops** — community bulk purchasing for raw feeders

Premium Sources:

- **Small local farms** — grass-fed, pastured animals; often sell organ bundles
- **Online raw pet food suppliers** — Darwin's Natural, My Pet Carnivore, Raw Feeding Miami, Hare-Today

Estimated Monthly Cost for a 95-lb German Shepherd

Protein Source	Avg. Cost/lb	Monthly Use	Monthly Cost
Chicken (quarters, backs)	$1.00–$1.50	14 lbs	$14–$21
Ground beef (80/20)	$3.00–$4.50	12 lbs	$36–$54
Ground turkey	$2.00–$3.00	8 lbs	$16–$24
Pork shoulder	$2.00–$3.50	6 lbs	$12–$21
Beef heart	$2.00–$3.00	5 lbs	$10–$15
Beef liver	$1.50–$2.50	2.5 lbs	$3.75–$6.25
Beef kidney	$1.50–$2.50	2.5 lbs	$3.75–$6.25
Other organs	$1.00–$3.00	2 lbs	$2–$6
Turkey necks	$1.50–$2.50	4 lbs	$6–$10
Vegetables/fruits	—	—	$15–$25
Eggs (dozen)	$3.00–$5.00	2 dozen	$6–$10
Sardines (canned)	$1.50–$2.00	4 cans	$6–$8
Supplements (kelp, fish oil, kefir)	—	—	$15–$25
TOTAL			**~$145–$231/month**

Comparison: Premium kibble for a 95-lb dog costs $80–$150/month. Quality raw feeding runs $145–$230/month — a modest premium for significantly superior nutrition.

Cost Reduction Tips

1. Buy in bulk and freeze — purchase when proteins are on sale
2. Build a relationship with a local butcher — organ meats are often nearly free
3. Join a local raw feeding co-op for bulk pricing
4. Use chicken as your daily base protein (cheapest per pound)
5. Source eggs locally or from Costco

Chapter 17: Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Do I need to worry about Salmonella? A: Your dog's stomach pH of 1–2 and short digestive tract evolved specifically to handle bacterial loads. Healthy adult dogs rarely develop illness from Salmonella in raw meat. The bigger concern is human contamination during handling — use the same practices you would preparing your own food.

Q: My dog has hip dysplasia — can raw feeding help? A: Yes. Anti-inflammatory omega-3 fatty acids (from fish), natural collagen from bones (glucosamine/chondroitin), and elimination of inflammatory grain-based kibble all support joint health. Add turmeric golden paste and ensure fish oil is consistent. Some owners also report improvement with green-lipped mussel supplementation.

Q: What if my dog refuses organs? A: Common initially. Try: (1) freeze then grate over meat, (2) lightly sear exterior 10 seconds per side, (3) mix into ground meat before serving. Most dogs accept organs within 2–4 weeks of being gradually introduced.

Q: Can I feed raw and kibble? A: Not ideally in the same meal. Different digestion rates cause fermentation and gas. If transitioning gradually, feed them at separate meal times.

Q: How do I know if my dog is getting enough calcium from bones? A: Stool is your indicator. Firm, small stools that turn white and crumble after 24 hours = adequate bone. Loose stools = too little bone. Rock-hard, crumbly stools immediately after defecation = too much bone.

Q: My dog's stool is sometimes white — is that bad? A: White stools indicate either excessive bone or high calcium intake. Reduce bone slightly and recheck within 2–3 days.

Q: Is raw feeding safe for German Shepherds specifically? A: German Shepherds actually tend to thrive on raw particularly well. The breed is prone to degenerative myelopathy, hip and elbow dysplasia, bloat (GDV), and skin/digestive issues. A raw diet addresses several of these through anti-inflammatory nutrition, improved gut microbiome, and maintained lean body condition. Note: regarding bloat risk, avoid vigorous exercise for 1–2 hours after large meals, and consider feeding two smaller meals rather than one large meal.

Q: Do I need to buy organic? A: Ideal but not required. Prioritize sourcing: (1) grass-fed/ pasture-raised for beef and lamb, (2) conventional for chicken is acceptable, (3) wild-caught for fish. Conventionally raised pork and poultry are fine when budget is a concern.

Q: What about parasites in raw meat? A: Freezing meat at 0°F for 3 weeks kills the vast majority of parasites including Trichinella (pork), Toxoplasma, and Sarcocystis. The exception is Neospora caninum in beef, which is not eliminated by freezing but is rare and typically only a concern for pregnant dogs. Purchase from reputable USDA-inspected sources.

Q: How long until I see results? A: Stool improvement: 2–4 weeks. Coat improvement: 6–8 weeks. Energy and body composition changes: 8–12 weeks. Full adaptation to the diet: 3–6 months.

Quick Reference Summary

Daily Targets — 95-lb Adult German Shepherd

Component	Daily Amount	Key Sources
Total Food	2.4 lbs	—
Muscle Meat	1.56 lbs (25 oz)	Beef, chicken, turkey, pork, lamb, duck
Raw Meaty Bones	0.36 lbs (5.8 oz)	Chicken quarters, turkey necks, lamb neck
Liver	0.12 lbs (1.9 oz)	Beef liver, chicken liver, lamb liver
Secreting Organs	0.12 lbs (1.9 oz)	Kidney, spleen, pancreas, thymus
Vegetables/Fruits	0.17 lbs (2.7 oz)	Kale, carrots, blueberries, zucchini
Boosters	—	Eggs (3–5/week), sardines (3–4/week), kefir
Fish Oil	2,000–3,000 mg EPA + DHA	Sardine oil, whole sardines

The Golden Rules of Raw Feeding

1. **Rotate proteins** — minimum 4–6 different proteins per week
2. **Liver = 5% only** — most critical limit in raw feeding
3. **Balance over time** — not every meal, every week
4. **Watch the stool** — it tells you everything
5. **Raw bones only** — never cooked
6. **Introduce organs slowly** — weeks, not days
7. **Freeze pork** — 3 weeks minimum before feeding
8. **Whole egg, not just whites**
9. **Pulp your vegetables** — dogs cannot digest intact plant cell walls
10. **Track BCS monthly** — adjust intake to maintain ideal body condition

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This guide was prepared as a comprehensive reference for feeding a 95-pound adult German Shepherd a biologically appropriate raw diet. Consult a holistic or raw-knowledgeable veterinarian for guidance specific to your individual dog's health status, particularly if your dog has any pre-existing medical conditions.

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